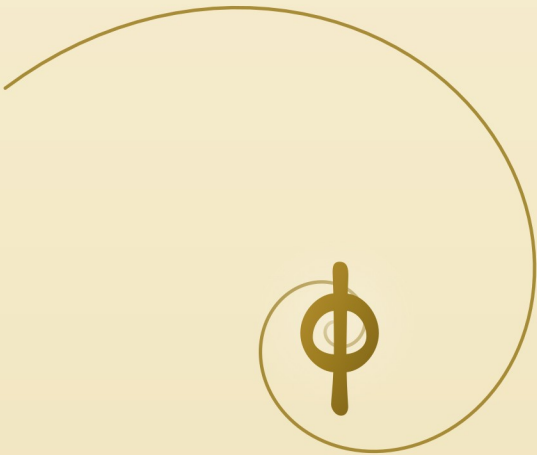


# PAINTIANO

## *The Book of Golden Music*

*On Finding Beauty Between Note and Color*



1.618 033 988 749 894 ...



*eighteen ways of looking*

RafFel

*paintiano.app · June 2026*

# PAINTIANO

## *The Book of Golden Music*

*On Finding Beauty Between Note and Color*



RafFel

June 2026

*Music is mathematics the ear can feel.  
An image is mathematics the eye can feel.  
This is a book about where they meet.*

— RafFel

# Contents

# Prologue

**I**magine sitting in a room that is, for some reason, completely silent. Not silent like a church, but silent like the first snow that settled on the roof a moment ago. In the room there is a piano. And before the piano, a canvas — white, still untouched, breathing in the light.

You press a single key. A tone sounds — maybe C, maybe F, it doesn't matter now. And in that same instant a mark appears on the canvas before you. Not drawn by hand, not projected by a camera: a real trace of colour that corresponds exactly to what you just played. You press a second key, a third, you begin to play a melody — and the canvas fills. Not chaotically, not as illustration, but by rules so deep in mathematics that you needn't know them to feel that it makes sense.

When you finish, you have a picture of your melody. And when you play it again tomorrow, exactly the same, exactly the same picture appears — as if music had a second form, one you could hang on the wall.

\* \* \*

That is Paintiano. Not the discovery of a law of nature — just a precise way to write music as an image and read an image as music. The way notes don't capture the whole of music, but are enough for it to be played.

It sounds new. It isn't. That music and image might be two faces of one thing was sensed by people long before

me — they simply lacked the instrument. This book is about that intuition as much as about the instrument. And your favourite song? It too has its colour. You just haven't seen it yet.

## *Chapter One*

# **Before Paintiano**

**I** had the idea as a boy, long before I knew what frequency was: that a tone has a colour. Not as a figure of speech, but as something that ought to be true. I didn't know what to do with it, so I just carried it — for years, like a pebble in my pocket.

Later I studied physics — the world of wavelengths and of waves that are also particles — and that old idea suddenly found a language. I understood why it wasn't as mad as it seemed: a tone and light really are the same wave, each merely vibrating at a different end of the same scale. Physics didn't give me Paintiano; it only showed me that what I carried inside didn't stand against the world, but with it.

And when I finally came back to it with tools I hadn't had as a boy, no struggle awaited me, but a flash of recognition — the thing suddenly fell into place, as if I were remembering something I'd known all along. No one ordered Paintiano, no one was waiting for it. I stayed with it for one reason only: once you've seen something you believe exists and no one has shown, it's hard to unsee. I say this only so you know that the book you're reading didn't grow from theory, but from an intuition carried a very long time. And when I once began to ask whether anyone before me had carried it too, I found that they had — and no ordinary ones. It belongs among the oldest intuitions humankind has.

## *Chapter Two*

# History of a Longing

**I**t began in Greece, about two and a half thousand years ago, with one man and one string. Pythagoras — the same one who gave his name to the theorem about triangles — stretched a string and listened. When he shortened it by half, the same tone sounded, only an octave higher: a ratio of two to one. When he shortened it to two thirds, a perfect fifth rang out: three to two. The concord that sounds sweet turned out to be a simple fraction; the discordant one, a complicated fraction. And Pythagoras grasped something that would shake the whole history of thought: beauty is not merely a mood. Beauty is also a number.

And if beauty is a number, he told himself, then music is not the only thing that sings. If concord is made of ratios, and ratios are everywhere — in the paths of the stars, in the proportions of the body, in the structure of the world — then the whole universe must sound. He called it the harmony of the spheres: a music the planets play by their motion, which we fail to hear only because it has sounded since our birth, and we have no silence against which to recognise it. It was a fantasy. But a fantasy with a core that was never lost again: that mathematics joins the senses, and that beneath the surface of difference lies a single order.

That idea outlived antiquity and became the backbone of medieval learning. Four of the seven liberal arts — arithmetic, geometry, music, and astronomy — formed the

quadrivium, and music in it was not an art. It was a mathematical science, the sister of geometry: the study of audible ratios. For centuries a child who was to become a scholar learned music as a kind of counting. And when, in 1619, Johannes Kepler published *Harmonices Mundi* — The Harmony of the World — it was not poetry. It was an astronomer's serious attempt to find the precise melodies the planets play by the speed of their orbits. He was looking for the notes of Saturn. He meant it entirely.

And then, at the threshold of modern science, the same search appeared where no one would expect it — in the soberest of men. When Isaac Newton split white light with a prism in 1666, he saw a continuous band of colour, a transition without borders. Yet he divided it into seven. Why seven? Because he was convinced there had to be order between colour and music — and there are seven tones in a scale. He added indigo, which no one before him had seen there and no one after him needs, just to make it come to seven. The father of modern physics, at his first sight of the spectrum, was looking for music. It was no marginal whim; it sat at the very heart of the scientific revolution.

In the eighteenth century the Jesuit Louis-Bertrand Castel came forward with what he called the *clavecin oculaire* — a harpsichord that, at every tone, opened a coloured shutter behind the keyboard. He was the first to stop merely dreaming the dream and begin building it. And the first to run into what would defeat everyone after him for the next two hundred years: the technology wasn't enough. The lamps were weak, the mechanisms heavy, the

light pale. The idea was right. The century had not yet caught up.

Others came after him, each with better technology and the same vision. In the nineteenth century the Englishman Alexander Wallace Rimington built a colour organ driven by electric arc lamps — bright enough, at last, for the light to blaze rather than fade. Scriabin, mystic and composer, wrote a separate part for light into the score of *Prometheus* — a keyboard of colours meant to play with the orchestra. And in the twentieth century the longing moved onto the cinema screen: in *Fantasia*, Walt Disney had his animators paint what they heard in Bach and Stravinsky — and millions of people saw, all at once and for the first time, music turning into image. When computers arrived, Castel's idea got its most widespread descendant: the music visualizer — those rippling colours that stir in your player when you start a track. The great-grandchild of Castel's harpsichord, carried in almost everyone's pocket.

And in our own day the same dream is embodied by David Byrne — a singer who never stayed with music alone. He turned an entire building into an instrument played by the wind and the footsteps of visitors. All his life he asks the same question as this book: why do we keep music and image apart, when they were always together inside us?

\* \* \*



Two and a half thousand years, one question. Pythagoras at his string, Kepler over the orbits of planets, Newton over the prism, Castel at his harpsichord, Disney at the cinema screen. Different hands, different centuries, the same dream. And here one must stop and ask: why? Why does humanity return to the same idea so stubbornly, again and again, with the tools of its age?

Not out of fashion — fashion doesn't last two and a half thousand years. It returns because a suspicion sits in us that cannot be quieted: that the division into heard and seen is not in the world, but in us. That tones and colours are not two things we try to bring close, but one thing we perceive with two senses, because we are too coarse to perceive it whole. So it is not a hunger to invent something. It is more like a memory — of a unity we are somehow convinced of, though we cannot quite recall it. And every colour organ, every keyboard of light, every Fantasia is an attempt to touch it again.

Yet all these forebears share one more thing: they were approximate. Castel matched colours by his own feeling, Rimington by his, Disney by whatever seemed beautiful. The visualizer in a player responds to loudness, but never

asks what the music is — it merely jumps about. None of them had a rule that was at once precise, shared, and reversible. Beautiful attempts, always an impression, never a translation. Centuries of searching, and the answer still missing.

And it is precisely here — after Pythagoras, after Kepler, after Newton — that the thing this book is about stands. Not another impression, but a rule: derived from the same mathematics Pythagoras heard in the string, exact in both directions, the same every time. Not because we are wiser than he was — but because for the first time we have both the mathematics and the machine to do what he only dreamed. What they reached for with the hands of their age, anyone today holds in their own. To Pythagoras it would have seemed a prayer answered. For you, it's enough to press a key.

## *Chapter Three*

# **The Golden Ratio**

**T**here is a number that can never be written down exactly. Another digit always escapes past the decimal point, and another, and another — endlessly, with no pattern, no rhythm, no end. It is called  $\phi$ . It is pronounced phi. And it is hiding all around you.

Its value is roughly 1.618. But its interest is not in the value — its interest is in the way it returns.

It is in the spiral of a snail's shell. In the arrangement of seeds in a sunflower. In the ratios between the bones of your index finger. In the proportions of the Parthenon — where architects, long before the calculator, built a façade that to a modern computer looks like a textbook example of the golden section. One should add:  $\phi$  is not always truly where we see it — people like to plant it where it doesn't belong. But even that says something: we look for it. As if the eye whispered that here, just here, there ought to be order.

It is in music. Bach used it in the structure of a fugue. Mozart divided sonata movements by it. Bartók used it openly — he said of it that some pieces have their climax exactly at the golden section, because that is where the ear expects it.

It is in paintings. Botticelli divided *The Birth of Venus* so that the centre of her body falls at the golden section of the canvas. Da Vinci studied it and drew it. Le Corbusier

made it the foundation of an entire architectural theory and called it the Modulor.

And it is in your eye, which, when it sees a composition divided at the golden section, says that is beautiful, even when it doesn't know why.

\* \* \*

The human brain has — no one knows exactly why — a peculiar fondness for this ratio. There is a hypothesis that it's because the golden ratio is the “least rational” number: the hardest to approximate with simple fractions. That is what makes it feel dynamic, unpredictable, alive. Other ratios — one half, one third, two thirds — are stable, but predictable. The golden ratio is stable and yet open. Like a good melody: you know where it's heading, and still it surprises you.

And this is the hypothesis on which Paintiano stands:

\* \* \*

*If phi holds such a universal beauty, it should  
be possible to build a bridge between what  
you hear and what you see.*

A bridge that needs no commentary. Tones turn into colours through a rule, not a mood — through a ratio that orders harmony in the ears and proportion in the eyes alike. I chose that rule; I did not find it ready-made in nature. But once you accept it, it holds firm and guides you the same way every time.

It is a bold hypothesis. Perhaps too bold. And if something in your head is already saying wait, that's too

pretty to be true — don't chase that voice away. Keep it close. We'll need it yet.

And let one thing be clear: the golden ratio is here not because it is necessary — but because it is convincing to me. That is a distinction I care about.

Paintiano is an answer that says: try it and see.

## *Chapter Four*

# **Tones Are Waves**

**I**n 1872, a strange figure of the Russian Silver Age was born in Moscow. His name was Alexander Scriabin, and he was — among other things — a composer. He was also a mystic, a prophet of his own end of the world, and a synesthete.

Synesthesia is a condition in which the senses don't mix, but overlap. Some synesthetes see letters in colour, some taste flavours while listening to music, and some — like Scriabin — see tones in particular colours. For Scriabin, C major was red. F major dark blue. E major a pearly blue. He drew maps of colours and painted tones.

He was a charming madman. He tried to build a keyboard of light — an instrument that, when a key was pressed, would flood the room with the corresponding colour. The premiere of his symphony *Prometheus* actually took place with this keyboard, though it didn't quite work as it should.

Scriabin died at forty-three, convinced that his last, unfinished work, *Mysterium*, would trigger the end of the world and the birth of a new era. It did not trigger the end of the world.

But he wasn't wrong about one thing: tones and colours have something in common.

\* \* \*

What that something is, we now know — and it isn't mysticism, but physics. It can be said in one sentence: sound and light are both waves. Sound is a periodic vibration of air — or water, or metal, depending on what it travels through. Light is a periodic vibration of the electromagnetic field. In both cases it is a wave that has a frequency. Our ears can hear frequencies from about twenty to twenty thousand hertz. Our eyes see frequencies from about four hundred and thirty trillion hertz (red) to seven hundred and fifty trillion (violet).

These are entirely different orders of magnitude, but the same physics. A wave is a wave.

And that means tones can be converted into colours — if you choose a rule that makes it possible. Not one to one, as with Scriabin — that would be too simple and, worse, arbitrary. Scriabin's map agrees with no other synesthete's map. Everyone sees a little differently.

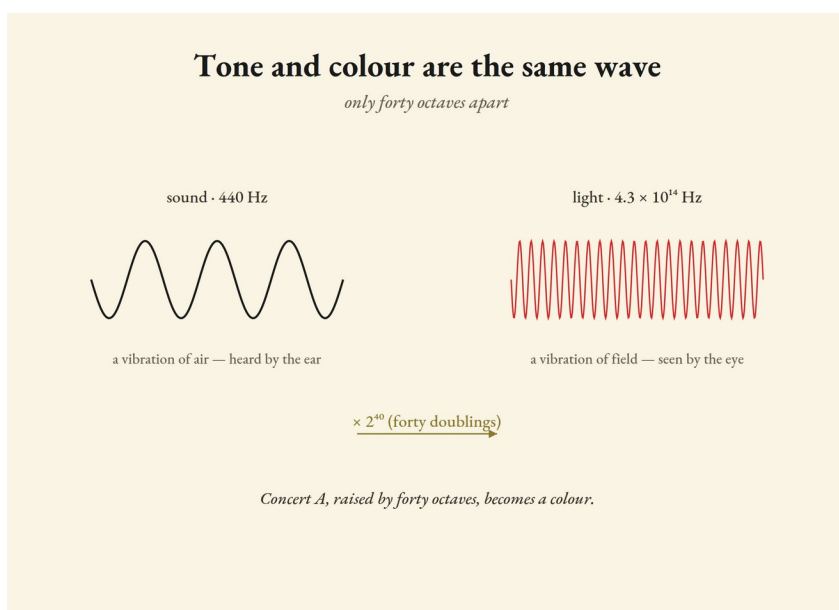
Instead of one person's individual map, a single consistent rule does the work here. And instead of a map for whole pieces, it makes a map for individual tones. So a piece doesn't give a palette as a whole — the palette is drawn by the individual tones that sound in the piece. As many tones, so many colours.

The twelve tones of the musical alphabet — C, C#, D, D#, E, F, F#, G, G#, A, A#, B — each get their own hue. And Paintiano offers you five different views on the question that troubled Scriabin all his life: what colour is C?

Harmony takes the old circle of fifths that holds Bach's fugue together and applies it to the colour wheel. Tones that sound akin to the ear get colours that are akin to the

eye. C and G, a fifth apart, sit side by side — to ear and eye it makes the same sense. The musician's view.

Spectrum throws theory overboard and arranges the tones like a rainbow. Each semitone thirty degrees on, no choice, no relationships — only number. And a graceful physics hides behind it: lift any tone by forty octaves and you land in visible light. Concert A — four hundred and forty hertz — becomes a warm red. Tones and colours are the same wave, only forty doublings apart. Spectrum doesn't compute that shift literally, though: the eye doesn't see even a whole octave, twelve semitones wouldn't fit into it. So it chooses an even division of the wheel instead of exact wavelengths — to survive the purple end of the rainbow too. Balance before physics. The physicist's view — one who knows when to stop measuring.

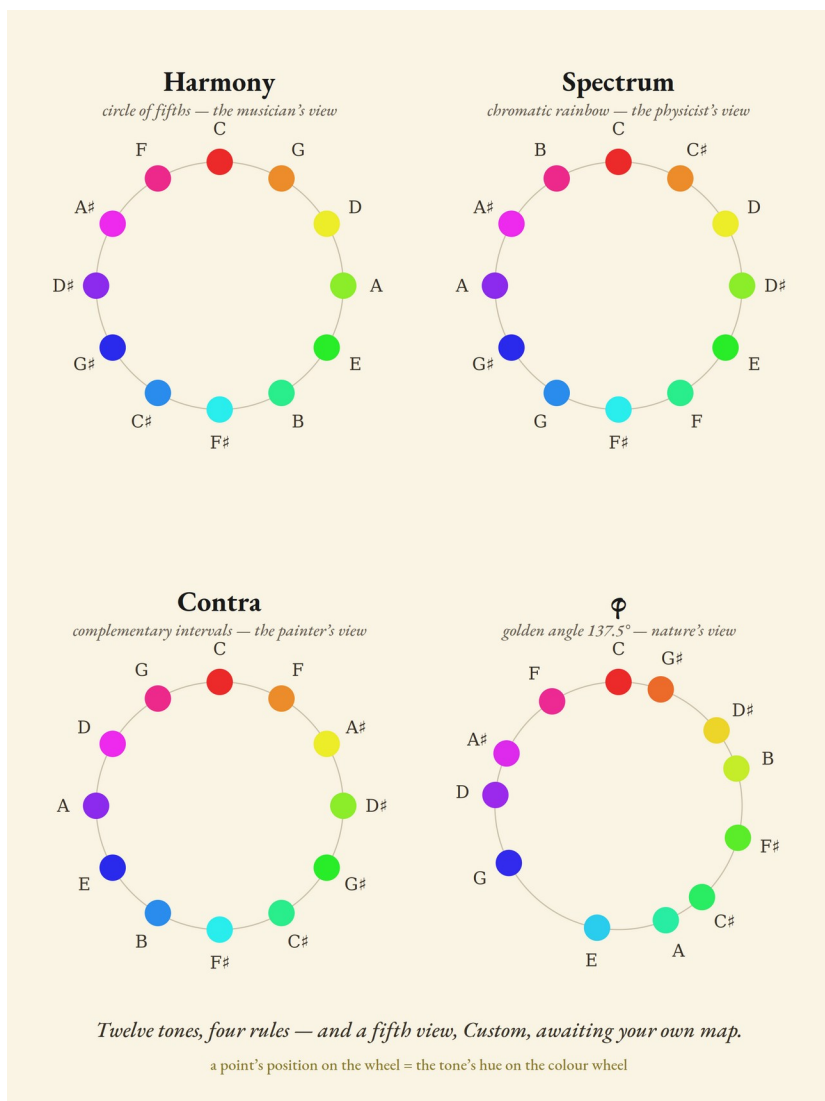


Contra is the mirror of Harmony. It takes its name from counterpoint — the old art of leading voices against each other so that concord arises precisely in the opposing motion: punctus contra punctum, note against note. Contra does the same with colours. In the painter's tradition, complementary colours — red and cyan, blue and orange — are considered “perfect partners”: together they create both contrast and balance at once. Contra carries this logic over to music: harmonic intervals get complementary pairs, dissonant ones get close hues. C and G, the purest fifth, lie exactly on opposite sides of the colour wheel — colour against colour, point against point. Where Harmony says “what sounds close, looks close,” Contra says “what sounds together, stands opposite.” The painter's view.

Custom is the fourth view — and the only one that is not a rule, but an invitation. It opens with the map of Alexander Scriabin: the real, historical one, the one he wrote for his Prometheus. C red, G orange, D yellow, A green — the circle of fifths coloured into a rainbow, exactly as that strange Russian saw it. And then you can rewrite it. Tell Paintiano what colour C is for you. What colour D is. The palette adapts and remembers. You begin with the map of a man who truly saw the colours of tones — and end with your own. Scriabin would be doubly glad: his map lives, and everyone may draw their own. The synesthete's view.

And finally  $\varphi$  — the rule every sunflower knows. Nature, when it lays seeds on a disc, turns each new one by an angle of one hundred and thirty-seven point five degrees: a full turn divided by  $\varphi$  squared. The mathematically most

efficient distribution of points on a circle that exists. The same botanical angle is applied to twelve tones. C red, C# one hundred and thirty-seven further on blue-green, D another one hundred and thirty-seven violet, and so on. Adjacent semitones are maximally far apart — no clusters, no neighbours. The sunflower uses that angle so the seeds don't block each other's sun. And here it serves so the tones don't block each other's colour. Nature's view.



\* \* \*

But hue isn't everything. A tone in a low octave gets a dark variant of its colour; the same tone in a high octave gets a light one. Bass C2 is dark blue, soprano C7 almost white. The octave determines lightness.

And how hard you press the key — the force of the stroke — determines saturation. A quiet stroke gives a faded colour. A full stroke gives a saturated one. Forte is saturated. Pianissimo is barely a shadow. So music gets its third dimension, the depth of colour, exactly where it has its dynamic mark in music.

None of this happens through metaphor. No one asks anyone: what's the feeling of this piece? Feeling isn't needed — or more precisely, the feeling is already encoded in the music being played. It's enough to read it.

\* \* \*

Here you may begin to wonder: where in all this is the golden ratio? The book is called *The Book of Golden Music*, after all. The answer is that the golden ratio is here twice.

First in the colour. That is precisely the  $\varphi$  mode — the botanical angle derived from  $\varphi$  squared, which spreads the tones across the colour wheel. When you choose this mode, every tone of the piece gets a colour by the rule that plants use to grow.

Second in the canvas. Every cell into which a single tone falls has a width-to-height ratio of one to  $\varphi$ . And the whole canvas — in live mode, while you play — has outer proportions in the golden ratio as well. So the golden ratio is not only one of the ways it is written, but also the geometry it is written into.

Just as a sonnet has fourteen lines regardless of what it's about, a picture from Paintiano has the proportions of  $\varphi$  regardless of what music it depicts. The form is given.

The choice of colour mode — Harmony, Spectrum, Contra, Custom, or  $\varphi$  — is yours.

\* \* \*

And to close, let's look together at one thing that holds me to this even now. This system is two-way. From music comes an image — that we already know. But from an image, music can be read. To Paintiano, an image is a grid of coloured cells. Every cell is read back: the hue tells you which note; the lightness tells you which octave; the saturation tells you how hard to strike. Load Picasso's *Guernica* and Paintiano will play it for you. Load a photo from your holiday and you'll hear how that beach sounded in the moment you caught it.

This is no trick. It is mathematical symmetry — a wave can be written as a colour and a colour written as a wave. The directional orientation (music  $\rightarrow$  image, or image  $\rightarrow$  music) is merely a cultural habit, not a physical necessity.

Paintiano is exactly that: a reader. It reads music and draws what it read. And when you turn the direction around, it reads an image and plays what it read.

*Farby sú činy svetla — jeho činy a jeho utrpenia.*

— Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, *Náuka o farbách*

*O dvesto rokov neskôr dodávame: aj tóny.*

# Synesthesia

**F**or some people the letter A is red. Not symbolically, not because they learned it somewhere — but really, always, from childhood: whenever they see A, it is red, the way grass is green. The number 5 is green. Wednesday is brown. And the name of a best friend has a taste they could describe.

For most people this sounds like poetry or raving. For a few percent of the population it is everyday reality. It is called synesthesia — from the Greek *syn* (together) and *aisthesis* (perception). The senses that run separately in others interweave in the synesthete: one stimulus automatically and involuntarily triggers a second experience.

You already know Scriabin — the one who saw keys as colours and wanted to build a piano out of light. But he was not alone. Vladimir Nabokov, the author of *Lolita*, had coloured letters and wrote whole pages about it. His mother had them too — and when, as a child, he said the colours of the letters on his wooden blocks were all wrong, she understood him. The composer Olivier Messiaen saw whole landscapes of colour in chords and wrote into his scores what colour was meant to sound — not for the performer, but for himself.

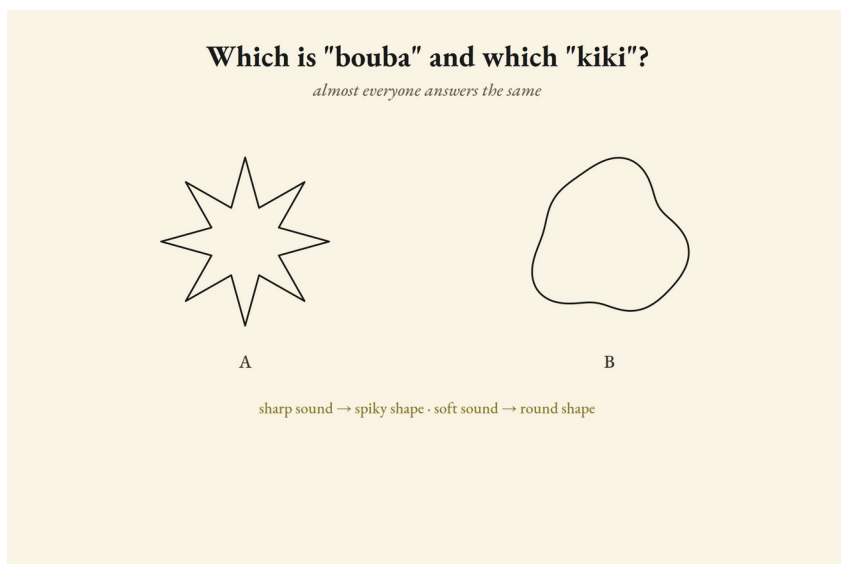
For a long time synesthesia was thought to be invention or disorder. Today we know it is real, measurable, and probably hereditary. Brain imaging of a synesthete shows

the visual areas lighting up at the sound of a tone — literally. Their brain really does have those pathways linked where most people's are separate.

\* \* \*

Here comes the surprise. Scientists who study synesthesia found something strange: although every synesthete sees a little differently, certain pairings recur more often than chance would allow. High tones tend to have light colours. Low tones dark ones. Sharp sounds sharp shapes, soft sounds rounded ones.

When you give people — non-synesthetes too — a choice of which of two shapes is called bouba and which kiki, almost everyone assigns kiki to the sharp one and bouba to the rounded one. Across cultures, across languages, across ages.



What does that mean? That the link between sound and image is not entirely arbitrary. That somewhere deep, below the level the will can reach, we all have a bit of the synesthete in us. That when you say a sharp tone or a warm colour or dark music, you aren't speaking a metaphor — you're saying something everyone understands, because it comes from the shared architecture of human perception.

And it is precisely on this that Paintiano stands. It doesn't pretend to be a synesthete — it has no brain, no experience. It does something else: it takes those non-random, broadly shared pairings and gives them a rule. A high tone gets a light colour, because that is how most people perceive it. A low tone a dark one. Distilled from what we have in common, and returned to everyone who opens it. Paintiano is synesthesia without the synesthete.

Synesthetes see music because they were born that way. With Paintiano, you can see it too. Not because anyone rewired your brain — but because the bit of the synesthete that always dozed in you finally got a canvas.

\* \* \*

And here the voice I told you to keep close must speak up. Imagine someone sitting beside you who doesn't believe a word. Right now they shake their head and say: "This is pseudoscience. You see an order you invented yourself, and you've called it a discovery. Boubas and kiki? A pretty game. But to build a rule for all of humanity on it — that is presumption."

They're right that it must be said aloud. And I won't refute that objection now — on the contrary, I'll let it hang. It will

return; a whole chapter belongs to it, later in this book, and then we'll see together what of all I've promised you here is left standing after it. For now let it hang. A good idea can bear resistance; only a bad one runs from it.

## Ten Ways of Looking

**T**he same music can look many ways. It depends on who is looking at it.

Let's begin with the simplest — two raw modes that belong to no painter. They are two ways music can show itself before any style has its say. They give you the bare principle on which everything else stands.

**Mosaic** is the basic grid. Each tone one cell, each cell one colour. No effects, no strokes, no metaphors. Pixel by pixel, note by note. A raw grid in which music gets its first visual form — and everything else Paintiano can do unfolds from it.

**Notes** do the most natural thing one can do with music: they name it. Each tone becomes its own name — C, D, G#, A# — written straight onto the canvas, in the colour it has in the current mode. The piece spreads out as a map of its own words; a field of namings, where each word is at once a sound and a colour. Music's own portrait — not through substitution, but through naming. A composition written in its own alphabet.

And now that you see the foundation, the painters enter. Ten of them — ten views of the same thing, chosen from a larger gallery. Not copies of their styles; a copy would be shallow. Rather a reading of music through the geometry and brush that characterised each painter. As if you invited them into the studio and said: this is my piece, please, you paint it.

Some stay close to Mosaic. Others tear it to pieces and put it back together. One floods it with gold. One reduces it to three colours. One dissolves it in light. One carves a wave from it. And one lets it rain.

Here they are.

\* \* \*

**Pablo Picasso** sees the world broken apart. Cube, edge, profile. One face from two sides at once. When he paints your music, the melody becomes fractured geometries; a chord, the clash of broken planes and sharp angles. Picasso tells you: everything you hear is made of tiny independent fragments I didn't dare to round off.

**Yayoi Kusama** sees the world through dots. Little half-spheres. Hundreds, thousands. When she paints your music, every tone becomes one sphere, one dot on an endless canvas. A quiet bar is a sparse field, a stormy bar a dense, starry Milky Way. Kusama tells you: there is no single thing; there is only many, many, many — and in that multitude is peace.

**Jackson Pollock** paints with gravity. The brush need not even touch the canvas; it's enough for the paint to fall. When he paints your music, the melody becomes the trajectory of a flying drop, a chord the fall of a whole cascade. With Pollock everything is gesture. There's no need to paint you something; it's enough to let it drop.

**Wassily Kandinsky** is the theorist. Yellow, he says, is C major. Blue, he says, is B minor. Geometric shapes — circle, triangle, square — are, he says, carriers of different energies. When he paints your music, he does so convinced that every note has its geometry and every

geometry its note. Kandinsky tells you: what you hear is not chance; it has laws, and those laws are elegant.

**Piet Mondrian** takes away. Three colours — red, yellow, blue — and two non-colours — white and black. A grid. No curves, no diagonals, no mercy. When he paints your music, the melody becomes a grid: a chord holds a corner, the melody holds a side, the tempo holds the proportion. Mondrian removed from the world everything that wasn't necessary — and what remained became the elements.

**Mark Rothko** paints fields of colour that seem to pulse from within. Large, almost monochromatic fields, blending softly at the edges. When he paints your music, he lets it spill. No shapes, no edges. Only colour and its precise feeling. Stop looking for a picture; look at what happens to you while you look.

**Gustav Klimt** blazes with gold. The Woman in Gold. The Kiss in gold. A canvas covered in gold leaf, patterns, ornament. When he paints your music, he gives it radiance. A chord becomes a field of gold, the melody an ornament rippling across it. Klimt tells you: beauty must be adorned; the ornament is not extra, the ornament is the essence.

**Bridget Riley** paints movement with stillness. Stripes, waves, chequerboards — sharp, black-and-white or colour — that seem to move before your eyes, though they don't move. Op art. When she paints your music, she gives it a vibration. The steady rhythm of the melody becomes a stripe, the harmonic shift of a chord becomes a wave. The eye can be fooled — and in that deception lies the beauty.

**Claude Monet** didn't paint things — he painted the light that falls on them. He painted the same cathedral at dawn and at dusk; they were not two pictures of a cathedral, but two pictures of light. When he paints your music, he breaks it into shimmering patches — no outlines, no edges, only tiny strokes of colour that from afar gather into an impression and up close fall apart into pure paint. A tone is not a point; a tone is the trembling of light on a surface. Monet tells you: I don't paint what I see — I paint how it shone in that moment.

**Katsushika Hokusai** carved the world into wood. The Japanese master of woodblock who, with *The Great Wave off Kanagawa*, gave the world a picture almost everyone knows: the wave lifted into claws of foam, beneath it tiny boats, in the distance a calm Fuji. When he paints your music, he gives it a wave — flowing contour lines, flat fields of colour, crests and troughs that rise and fall with the melody. Hokusai knew what your book says from the start: a tone is a wave. He merely drew it. Hokusai tells you: even the greatest surge is just a line a hand knows how to lead.

\* \* \*

Ten views. The same piece sounds and you see it ten different ways. Sometimes you're sure that this Picasso gives you what it should, and another misses. Sometimes it surprises you that Rothko did best by your sad ballad — because you hadn't noticed how much silence is in it. It isn't only about pretty pictures — it's about seeing all that music contains when you let it project into different minds.

And here a question may occur to you that these pages won't answer: what would yours look like? The song sounding in your head right now — through Picasso, through Rothko, through Hokusai? You won't learn that from the book. It can only be seen.

\* \* \*

Ten painters and two raw modes — that is what fit on these pages. But it isn't all Paintiano knows. I chose ten, because ten is enough to grasp the principle — and these ten in particular, because they resemble one another least.

This book is a gallery — only as much fit into it as a single walk can bear. But beyond its walls is a whole house that never closes: more painters, more modes, and one day an empty canvas onto which you'll write your own rule. You can walk through a gallery. Not through a house. That is the difference between them — and the whole point.

## *Chapter Seven*

# **Palette and Attention**

**T**he dream of an instrument that paints is old — we saw it in the history, from Castel’s harpsichord to Disney’s screen. Paintiano is its newest form: a colour organ of the twenty-first century, where the keys play and paint at once and the canvas is a screen. Every touch of the piano leaves a trace that matches what you played.

It had one more relative, though, this time in literature. In *Froth on the Daydream*, Boris Vian’s 1947 novel, there appears the pianocktail — a piano that, instead of light, mixes cocktails. The chord sets the proportion, the dynamics the strength, the tempo the temperature; the player plays some Duke Ellington and into the glass flows a drink exactly to the piece. It was only a poetic idea, a novel, not an instrument. And yet Vian wrote down precisely the principle on which Paintiano stands today: one input, music; another output, something sensory you can hold in your hands. There, a glass. Here, an image.

\* \* \*

But the piano is only one door. Music doesn’t come only from under the fingers — it’s in the voice you hum on the way home, in the track playing from a speaker, in the song someone recorded a hundred years ago that you put on today. It’s also where you don’t expect it: in an image that can be read as a melody, in a sentence spoken aloud, in the random sound of a room. Each of these is a different

window into the same thing — and music, in whatever form life brings it to you, has its visual shape, which is here for you to see.

\* \* \*

But for that shape to arise, one more thing is needed that is not in the instrument, but in you: the willingness to play. A grown person is a child who has forgotten they may play — and yet play is a serious thing. Without it there would be no science, no art, no mathematics; Newton played with gravity, Einstein with time, Picasso with the cube. It is the way the mind explores while it still doesn't know what it's doing.

Paintiano is exactly such play. When you open a blank canvas and press the first key, you wake in yourself something that began to fall asleep around the age of seven — and that adulthood only covered with cares, did not destroy. Children catch it at once: a three-year-old girl presses a key, sees the trace and cries out in surprise, and then another and another, until the canvas is covered with traces she hasn't yet named. Adults are quiet at first. They try one key, a second. Ah, they say — and then they play.

Because Paintiano gives you no task. It doesn't say today you will create a masterpiece. It says play and see. And it's a game in which no one tells you when you've finished, because there is always one more piece you have never seen.

\* \* \*

And there is a second way to play — one in which you don't play, but listen. What is the ability to hear called? Hearing. And the ability to listen? Attention.

Until now you composed sound — tone by tone, key by key. But sound cannot only be composed; it can also be listened to. And that is a different relationship. When you compose, you set every tone yourself. When you listen, you receive the sound whole — as it comes, whether it's your voice, someone's recording, or the rain outside the window — and let it become visible. You don't have to make it. It's enough to pay it attention.

You put on a track from a speaker — say a Bach concerto. The sound comes in and something listens to it attentively: how the chords alternate, how the melodies move, how the tempo holds the structure. And before you an image arises. Not identical to the recording; closer to an understanding of the recording. As if you retold a book in your own words — the text is no longer exact, but the spirit is.

Or you sing a melody yourself. Something listens. Here you need no chords or harmony — the bare voice is enough, the melody is itself. You sing your sorrow, your joy, the refrain you made up in the car — and at every tone a colour arises. You don't have to know how to sing. Nothing judges you; it only listens.

\* \* \*

And the instrument of that attention has a quite ordinary name: a microphone. The keyboard is intimate — fingers and keys, one tone after another. The microphone is wide — the ear spreads across the room and listens to

everything. Including you. Including friends singing together in the car. Including the song that played on the radio a moment ago, because you were enchanted by it and wanted to know what it would look like.

## *Chapter Eight*

# One Day

**I**t is Wednesday, half past four in the afternoon, and in the flat on the fourth floor there is the kind of silence there is only when someone is crying quietly, so as not to be heard.

Lara is seven. She sits at the kitchen table, a tablet before her, and doesn't know what to do with herself. Her hamster died this morning. His name was Chestnut. Mum said it's part of life, and Dad said they'd buy her a new one, but Lara doesn't want a new one, Lara wants Chestnut, and that can't be — and that is exactly what makes today so hard: that some things simply can't be.

Her father, who doesn't know what to say, does what parents do when they don't know what to say: he hands her something. Look, he says, this might be interesting. He opens for her the thing he read about. A white canvas. A piano. Try to play how you feel.

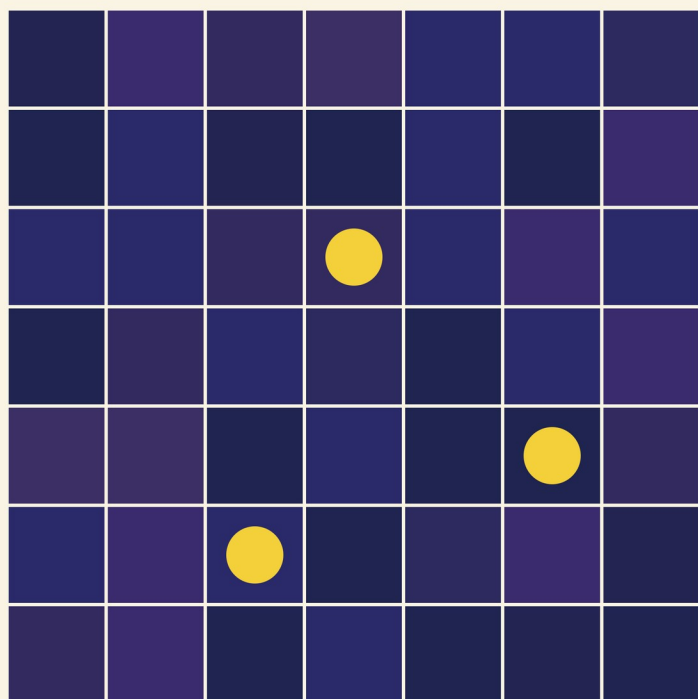
Lara looks at it. How I feel. That's a silly question, because she has no words for it — she is seven, with a sorrow bigger than herself. But she has fingers, and the keys are there, so she presses one. A low one. A dark blue patch spreads across the canvas.

She presses it again. And again. Slowly, because she doesn't feel like being quick. The canvas fills with dark blue, dark violet, in places almost black — colours she didn't choose, that simply came, because that's how it is in those tones. And Lara, who all morning couldn't say a

single word about what she feels, suddenly sees before her something that says it for her.

This. This is what today looks like.

No one taught her. No one told her that sorrow is blue — she just played it, and it came out that way, because low slow tones give dark quiet colours, and that is mathematics, not chance. But Lara knows nothing of mathematics. Lara knows only that for the first time all day she doesn't feel alone, because something in the world looks exactly the way she feels.



*"That is Chestnut. When he still was."*

low slow tones → dark colours · one higher tone → yellow

She plays on. And somewhere around the tenth patch something small happens: among the blue one higher tone slips in. Light. By accident. A yellowish dot in the middle of the dark field. Lara stops. She looks at it. And — not because her sorrow is gone, but because that's how it is with us — she presses one more light one. And one more.

When her father looks into the kitchen half an hour later, Lara is no longer crying. She is intently composing a picture no one else in the world has or will have, because it is the picture of her Wednesday, her Chestnut, her seven years. Her father says nothing. He sits down beside her. What is it, he asks at last.

It's Chestnut, Lara says. From when he still was.

And that is all. No great healing, no end of sorrow. Only a little girl who found a way to say the unsayable — not with words she doesn't yet have, but with colour that came from tones that came from how she felt.

This is what happens when music gets a body that can be seen. It is not a miracle. It is only a translation — from a language we feel but cannot speak, into a language we see. And sometimes, on a Wednesday at half past four, such a translation is the only thing a person needs.

## Chapter Nine

# The Picture That Plays

Until now we went one way: music in, image out. You press a tone, a colour arises. You play a piece, you get a canvas. It is the natural direction, the one you expect.

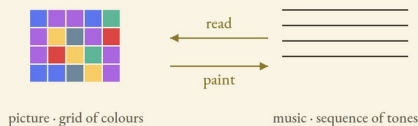
But Paintiano can also do the reverse. And that reverse is something that startles everyone the first time.

You load an image — any image. A holiday photo. A reproduction of Picasso's *Guernica*. A child's drawing. A shot of the sky before a storm. And it plays it for you.

How is that possible? Remember what an image is to Paintiano: a grid of coloured cells. And remember what the rule that turns tone into colour does — it assigns pitch to hue, octave to brightness, stroke-force to saturation. This rule has one beautiful property: it can be turned around. If you can make a colour from a tone, you can make a tone from a colour. You just read the table backwards.

### There and back, without loss

*the same rule holds in both directions*



*hue → pitch · brightness → octave · saturation → force*

So the image is gone through cell by cell. Dark blue at the top left? That's a low tone, quietly. Light yellow beside it? A high tone, loud. Row by row, like the eyes in reading, it turns a field of colours into a sequence of tones — and that sequence is music you can hear.

Here the surprising thing happens. Because no one composed that image as music. Picasso wasn't thinking of a melody when he painted *Guernica*. And yet — when it plays, it is not random noise. A dark, stormy canvas sounds dark and heavy. A cheerful child's drawing full of yellows and reds chirps high and fast. A sunset spills out in long warm tones. The image sounds the way it looks — because the same rule that joined pitch to light and force to saturation holds equally in both directions.

Try something. Photograph your favourite wall. The picture that has hung in the living room for years and that you no longer notice. And have it played. Suddenly you hear something you've seen a thousand times and never heard. The same surface, two senses. The wall you know by heart has a melody you never knew of.

Or turn it once more and spin in a circle: load an image, have it played as music — and let that music be painted again. You get a new image, kin to the original but not identical, because on the way through sound something was recast. It's like translating a poem into another language and back: it returns changed, and in that change you see what is essential about it and what was only the chance of form.

This is no trick or effect. And it is the strongest hint of the thesis on which the whole book stands: that music and image may not be two things to be joined, but one thing

seen from two sides. I don't prove it — I only show it to you as close up as I can. And Paintiano is the place where one passes between those two sides as easily as turning one's head.

\* \* \*

And from that same two-sidedness comes one more thing worth its own reflection. When you listen to a piece, you hear it in time. Tone after tone, bar after bar, from start to finish. Music flows around you like a river — and like a river, you never see it whole at once. Only ever the place where you are right now.

An image is different. You see an image whole in one instant. It stands before you, edge to edge, the past and future of the piece at once on one surface. And that changes everything — because suddenly you see things you cannot hear.

Imagine a fugue. When you listen to it, you know there is a theme that returns — the ear catches it when it sounds. But only Paintiano shows you that it returns exactly here, and here, and here again, at equal intervals, like columns in a colonnade. Suddenly you see the architecture Bach built — you don't hear it, but you see how the pattern falls onto the canvas in a regular rhythm that escaped you in the stream of time.

Or the reverse. A piece that sounded simple to you turns out on the canvas to be surprisingly rich — full of small irregularities, shifts, places where something quivered. You didn't hear them, because they passed too quickly. But the eye sees them, because the eye has time.

The image stops the music and holds it for you, so you can look properly.

\* \* \*

This is the quietest, but perhaps deepest, ability of Paintiano. It is not about making pretty pictures. It is about understanding all that music contains — when you let it project into a space where nothing runs away.

Musicians have known this long, only differently. A score is in fact also an image of music — tones lie laid out across the paper so the eye sees them at once. A conductor reads from the score the structure a listener only senses. It does the same, but without needing to read notes. It turns a piece into an image and the structure appears on its own — you see the repetitions, you see the build-up, you see where it climaxes and where it breathes, because all of it becomes visible in the image as shape.

There is something almost detective-like in it. You take a piece you've loved for years and let it show its skeleton. And often you discover why you love it — you see that hidden symmetry, that secret ordering that worked on you long before you could point a finger at it. The beauty had a reason. It was just hidden in time, and Paintiano laid it out in space.

And then one more thing happens. You begin to listen differently. Once you've seen what is hidden in music, the ear learns to look for it. You return to the piece, close your eyes — and suddenly you hear the symmetry the image first had to show you. It won't teach you to draw. It will teach you to listen better.

# **Determinism and Freedom**

**C**ontemporary art often boasts that it is always new. An image generator sends you a different image at every prompt, even when you enter the same thing. Boundless possibilities, the freedom of chance, the delight of the lover of repetition and variation.

Paintiano stands on the opposite side. The same input constellation — the same piece, the same artist, the same colour mode, the same canvas size — always produces the same image. Determinism is a fixed rule. No chance.

Why? Because chance lowers responsibility. When the result is random, the maker need not ask why it is the way it is. When the result is deterministic, the question why returns: why did you choose this, and not that?

Determinism is, in Paintiano, a form of honesty. When you play a piece and an image arises, that image is not the magic of surprise; it is the consequence of what you did. Your freedom lies in what you choose before painting — which piece, which artist, which colour mode. Once you've chosen, the result is fixed. As when you choose a score: when you play it the same, the music sounds the same. The composer didn't entrust the music to chance; he entrusted it to notation. And just so the image is entrusted here to the notation of music.

But here one must be precise, so as not to deceive you — or myself. Determinism means the rule is fixed and the

same every time. It doesn't mean it is the one right rule. That something always comes out the same doesn't make the result a truth about the world — it only makes it honest and repeatable. A spreadsheet also gives the same sum every time, and yet it isn't an image of reality. Paintiano is no exception: its rule is consistent, not sacred. And that is precisely why Paintiano has not one mode, but five.

\* \* \*

Here something happens that's worth looking at together. Your image is yours — no one else has it in that moment. And yet anyone who played the same as you would get the same image. That means the image is not unique because of chance; it is unique because of a decision. When you chose what to play, you chose exactly what you would draw. If you were a different person, you would choose a different piece. Your image doesn't say: chance determined it; your image says: you determined it.

This is a very old idea. Aristotle speaks of it. Bach speaks of it. The Bauhaus speaks of it. Beauty isn't in its having come out by chance; it is in its having come out exactly, because I wanted it to come out exactly.

*Music is the space between the notes.*

— attributed to Claude Debussy

*And colour is what you see in that space.*

# The Interpreter

**T**here is one more gate into music — for the one who can neither play nor sing, but can say what they feel. It is opened by artificial intelligence, and precisely for that reason one must be exact, because today the word AI is easily mistaken for something it is not here.

This is not an image generator. Paintiano doesn't tell the artificial intelligence paint me a picture. It tells it something far humbler: translate this mood into music, and the music we'll handle ourselves. Imagine a restaurant. You tell the waiter you'd like something fresh, summery, that would taste like Tuscany in June. The waiter doesn't make the dish — he looks into the kitchen and tells the cook what you wanted; and the cook, who knows his ingredients, prepares it. The AI here is that waiter. You say a calm summer rain in the sun; it writes from that a short piece carrying that mood — a few low tones, a few high. But the image you finally see is the work of Paintiano, not of the AI: once the piece exists, it is repainted by Paintiano's own mathematics, its own golden ratio.

So it is an interpreter — a bridge between what you can't say in notes and a system that understands only notes. And it helps in another way too: when you load an image and want not only music but also a mood to come from it, it looks at the image and says a single word — melancholic, stormy, festive. Nothing more; no new

image, just one adjective, a coordinate on the colour map. And the rest, as always, is done by mathematics. Because that is the boundary I care about. The AI is exactly where one must cross from human speech or from a photograph into music — and not a step further. Where mathematics suffices on its own, it touches nothing. And should some newer technology one day take over that interpreting task, the essence stays the same and will not age: to translate a human sentence into music, and leave the music to mathematics. Mathematics is older. It has its own elegance. Mathematics needs no help.

## *Chapter Twelve*

# **The Objection**

**U**p to now this book has spoken in one voice. It persuaded you, enthused you, led you from one epiphany to the next. And it is time to admit: every book that only persuades and never doubts is keeping something back. So let us stand for a moment on the other side — against everything I've claimed so far. Because an idea that fears its opponents isn't worth believing.

Let us, then, put three questions, and put them hard. What if beauty is not mathematical — what if what moves us lies precisely beyond the reach of any formula? What if the translation between music and image is always lossy, and what we get is only an echo, not the thing itself? And what if the synesthetic links are not universal but largely learned — and the whole foundation of the book is therefore softer than it pretended?

The first objection is the hardest, and it comes from people who have thought about beauty longer than I have. It runs thus: beauty resists the formula. What makes a Vermeer moving is not a distribution of hues that can be measured — it is something that escapes every table. When you turn music into colours by a rule, you get a correlation, not beauty. A map, not the territory. And to reduce art to a function, they say, is to kill the very thing that matters.

The second objection is quieter, but perhaps deeper. Every translation loses something — anyone who has read

a poem in two languages knows it. And the translation between music and image may be lossy in principle, not only in practice. Perhaps what Paintiano makes is not music seen differently, but only its shadow. A thing that resembles, but is not the same. A pretty lie that two worlds are one.

The third objection attacks the very foundation. The whole book rests on our sharing the links between sound and image — bouba and kiki, a high tone and a light colour. But synesthetes don't agree among themselves; the same tone one sees red, another blue. And the bouba/kiki test fails in some languages. What I passed off as the shared basis of human perception may be in part a cultural habit — and to build a universal rule on it is presumption.

And finally the golden ratio. In popular culture it has become a magic number said to govern everything from a snail's shell to the Parthenon. But most of these claims are imposed after the fact — measure enough things and something always comes out close to  $\phi$ . To claim the golden ratio is the secret language of beauty is romance, not proof. And I celebrated it in this book as a truth of the universe.

\* \* \*

Now I'll answer. Not to defeat those objections — some cannot be defeated — but to say what of my thesis still stands after them. Because something does.

To the first: you're right, and I never claimed otherwise. Paintiano doesn't say what is beautiful. It gives no marks, passes no judgments on taste. It does something far

humbler — it gives a tone a colour by a fixed rule, there and back, the same every time. It is a grammar, not a verdict. Just as notes don't say which piece is beautiful — they only write it down so it can be read. Paintiano is not a judge of beauty. It is its scribe.

To the second: yes, translation loses — but that is not a flaw, that is the whole point. Remember the image that returns changed when it passes through sound and back. Precisely in what is lost you see what was essential about it and what was only the chance of form. And unlike most translations, the one from Paintiano is reversible — not a shadow, but the other side of the same coin. Perhaps it isn't the whole truth. But it is a truthful view.

To the third and fourth together: you're right that it isn't universal — and Paintiano never needed it to be. It doesn't ask whether you see exactly what your neighbour sees. It asks only whether there is enough shared inclination for the translation to make sense — and that inclination really does exist. And when you disagree? Remember the four fixed wheels — Harmony, Spectrum, Contra, and  $\varphi$  — and the fifth, Custom, empty, waiting for you. The golden ratio is not a law of the universe. It is one choice among many, which I chose for its properties, not because God commanded it. Your map can be different. Nothing stands in your way.

And there is one more objection, the most uncomfortable, because it aims at a word I've used from the start: translation. Because honestly — Paintiano doesn't translate the way one translates from one language to another, where the words already exist and need only be carried over. No rule says that this particular

C must be this particular red. I chose it so. I could have chosen otherwise — and in other modes I did choose otherwise. What I call translation is in truth a decision. A map no one found in nature; a map I drew.

I admit it gladly, because it is not a weakness — it is the whole point. If there were one true translation between tone and colour, Paintiano would have one mode, not five, and that last one, Custom, would not wait empty for you. Paintiano is not the discovery of a hidden law. It is a proposal — one coherent, considered way to join two worlds, which I offered you because it is beautiful and it works, not because it is the only one possible. I am not telling you here is the truth. I am saying look this way — and you'll see more.

And now what, as an author, I would most gladly keep silent. Because one of those objections I didn't disarm — I only sidestepped. The first, the aesthetician's: that beauty resists the formula. I said Paintiano doesn't judge beauty, only writes it down. But that is an evasion. The truth is, I have no idea whether what I call a bridge between tone and colour is a discovery or only a pretty wish I taught myself to see. Perhaps the aesthetician is right and I am wrong at the very core. Perhaps between Bach's fugue and its image there is no deeper bond — only my longing for there to be one. This question I cannot close. I leave it open, because to close it by force would be a lie.

So what remains, when the big words have fallen? This remains: not a proof, but an invitation. This book is not an indictment meant to convict you of the truth. It is a view — one way of looking at a world in which music and image are not as far apart as we've grown used to thinking.

Perhaps I'm wrong. But if there is even a small chance that tone and colour are two faces of the same thing, it's worth opening your eyes and looking. Doubt doesn't kill wonder. It only makes it more honest.

\* \* \*

And since I've come this far in confessing, I'll say the rest — the part I write as if at night, because by day I trust myself. By day I'm an author who knows what he built. At night I'm only a man unsure whether what he built means anything at all. And since the whole book was about honesty, it would be cowardly to end it before I say this too.

I have three doubts. I won't rid myself of them by painting over them with a pretty sentence — so I'll say them bare, the way they wake me.

First: what if beauty is entirely subjective? What if there is no "that is beautiful," only "I like it" — and I made a book of my personal fondness as if it were a law? Maybe C isn't red for anyone but me. Maybe the whole bridge I built leads only from my head into my head.

Second: what if I see order where there is none? The human brain is a machine for patterns — it sees faces in clouds and intent in chance. What if all of Paintiano is only a beautiful pareidolia? What if I assembled  $\phi$ , harmony, and synesthesia into a story only because I wanted the world to be more ordered than it really is?

The third is the worst, because I have no clean answer to it. What if Paintiano doesn't reveal music, but creates it — another layer that has nothing in common with the original piece except that I joined them? What if I am not a

translator, but a forger, manufacturing an impression of depth where there is none?

\* \* \*

And now the answer — not a proof, only the peace with which I can fall asleep. Perhaps yes. Perhaps beauty is subjective, perhaps I project order, perhaps I create rather than reveal. I grant all three. I can't refute them and I won't pretend I can.

But interpretation too is a way of knowing. The map is not the territory — and yet maps carried us across oceans. When I look up at the night sky and see the Great Bear, I know those stars are not a bear, that nothing joins them but my gaze. And yet that bear exists — because I see it, I'll show it to you, and you'll see it too. It is no less real for being human.

So perhaps Paintiano is not the truth about music. Perhaps it is only one beautiful way of looking at it. But to choose to see beauty where there might be only noise — that is not a lie. That is courage. And that is exactly what I wanted to give you with this book: not the certainty that I am right, but the permission to look and decide for yourself.

*I see music when I listen to it, and I hear  
colours when I see them.*

— words attributed to many synesthetes, to no one and to  
everyone

*This book was about how anyone can see it.*

## *Chapter Thirteen*

# RafFel

**N**aming is a serious thing. When an artist gives himself a name, he tells the world: this is who I'll be when I do this. A different name means a different mode — a different seriousness, a different register, a different way in which he may go wrong.

Moses hesitated, for he had a slow tongue, but once God named him, he went. Picasso was not Picasso; he was Pablo Diego José Francisco de Paula Juan Nepomuceno Crispín Crispiniano Ruiz Picasso. He chose one short name of his mother's and lived as Picasso, because it was a name that fit on paintings.

RafFel is the name I chose. I live under it and create under it. Conceptual art. Conceptual — meaning the work is not in the object; the work is in the idea. The object is a consequence.

And since I've mentioned where I look from — I have physics behind me, though I don't say it to lend Paintiano scientific weight. Paintiano didn't grow from physics and doesn't need it as a crutch. When I write in this book that tone and light are the same wave, it is not a figure I borrowed from a textbook — it is a thing I computed for years at the blackboard. An artist who happened to look through physics as well.

\* \* \*

Paintiano is my conceptual work. The object is an instrument that paints music. The idea is: music and image are one phenomenon, which can be separated only the way water is separated from ice — physically, but not in essence. If this is true, it can be proven. And the proof is not written in a treatise; the proof is demonstrated by your being able to open it and play it yourself. If it makes sense to you, if it gets under your skin, the proof has passed.

This is an ambitious form. Much conceptual art today relies on explanation, on text, on a curator who says: this means. I decided to try it without explanation. If you have a piano and a canvas before you and you press a key and a trace appears, you don't need a curator. You'll understand it yourself.

Perhaps this is the boldest part of the project: humility before the user. No prefaces. No catalogue texts. Only: here is an instrument, play.

And yet you hold a book in your hands — so allow one sentence in its defence, lest you read it as an advertising flyer. This book is not an advertisement for Paintiano. It is part of the work. If I only wanted you to try the instrument, a link and three sentences would do. But a conceptual work is the object and the idea together, and the idea needs words the way the instrument needs keys. The instrument alone would show you what Paintiano does; only this book tells you why I had to make it.

(In fact, one such text is here after all — the prologue at the start of this book. But even that doesn't announce what you should think; it only tells a story, so you know what the instrument holds within when you reach for it.)

# Epilogue

**T**his was a book about one idea. That music always had its second face — visible, drawable, hangable on a wall. That between tone and colour runs a bridge one can cross both ways. You don't have to believe me. It's enough if you look once and decide for yourself.

\* \* \*

Be patient with yourself. The first touches don't sound or look like a concert. The second, better. The third will show you who you are when you're not thinking about who you are. The fourth will already be yours.

And then — when you stand before an image you made from a song of your childhood, from a piece you just invented, or from a cry you made into the microphone — perhaps you'll understand why all of this exists. Not so you make pretty pictures. But so you see something that was always there, and that we only stopped believing in.

Because what this book has been searching for all along can be said in one sentence: it is synesthesia without the synesthete. The ability to see music — once reserved for the handful born with it — returned to everyone who looks. Not by a miracle in the brain, but by a rule on the canvas. That is all. That is the old longing, at last with a shape you can hold.

\* \* \*

*Music always had its colour.  
We had only forgotten.  
Now we remember.*

---

*Paintiano is not just an idea in a book.  
It is also an instrument you can open — free, no account.  
The book says why. The instrument shows how.*

[paintiano.app](https://paintiano.app)

*Colophon*

*Paintiano — The Book of Golden Music*

First edition · June 2026

RafFel

(Rasťo Ďurica)

[paintiano.app](https://paintiano.app)

*Set in EB Garamond.*

*Made with love for the golden ratio.*





*"Music has color.  
It always did.  
We only forgot."*

---

Paintiano is a conceptual work that turns music into paintings — through the golden ratio, through eighteen painters, through deterministic mathematics. Press a key, a mark appears. Play a melody, a painting appears.

The same piece is played and you see it eighteen different ways. Picasso fractures the shape, Pollock lets paint fall by gravity, Kusama sees the world through dots, Klimt shines in gold. Eighteen ways of looking at the same sound — each one true.

This little book tells the story of why such a thing exists at all. And why, perhaps, it needed to come into being.

---

**RafFel**

*(Rasto Ďurica)*

paintiano.app

Bratislava · June 2026